

SRINAGAR | Collateral Slaughter



AP PHOTO/DAR YASIN

Kashmir is raging over the death of 11-day-old Irfan Ahmed amid protests in Baramulla on February 22. An infant has paid the heaviest cost and once again the state is divided over who is responsible. The police were quick to blame the stone-throwing protesters for

STONE-PELTING PROTESTERS ARE BEING BLAMED FOR AN INFANT'S DEATH IN J&K

Ahmed's death, but it is unclear who were in the two vehicles that stopped the car in which the family was taking the ill child to a hospital. The incident happened during protests seeking the release of about a hundred boys detained across the Valley recently for pelting stones during demonstrations. Some of the boys have been charged with "waging war against the nation".

Said A.Q. Manhas, DIG, Baramulla, "The infant died in the attack by those protesters. The murderers will be punished." The incident has triggered a debate whether the child died as a result of a stone-throwing protest, one of many spreading across the state. *by Aijaz Hussain*



The Marxist mayor of Kollam in Kerala lit the lamp to inaugurate an RSS office in the city and paid homage to Hedgewar and Golwalkar, promising the Hindutva outfit all help. Comrades in God's Own Country are, well red-faced.

PATNA | Dance Drama

The more things change the more they stay the same. That perhaps explains why JD(U) MLA Shyam Bahadur Singh was gyrating in quite a lewd manner with bar dancers at his official residence while entertaining a group of Mahadalit rally participants. Convened by the National Democratic Alliance, the rally intended to express the state Government's commitment towards the Mahadalits, the most deprived groups among the Scheduled Caste population. As TV channels beamed the dance show, it triggered a wave of sharp censure from the Opposition. Singh apologised a day later and even offered to resign. The next day he was back to defiance, promising to dance again on Holi. Incidentally,



KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

SINGH WITH THE BAR DANCERS

Bihar Assembly Speaker Udai Narayan Choudhary, who is constitutionally required to remain neutral, is also at the centre of Opposition criticism due to his active participation in the Mahadalit rally. *by Amitabh Srivastava*

DELHI | Home Run

When recently described as the man holding the most important job in the country, P. Chidambaram laughed, saying, "If the home minister has the most important job, it means the situation is not good." The suave home minister was at his charming best as he answered questions at the Indian Women's Press Corps. He explained that he was more accessible as home minister than as finance minister because the former needs to communicate more. "Finance is more of an esoteric subject, there are less people interested in lending rates while Home affects a vast majority of people". The no less esoteric Chidambaram sidestepped all comparisons to Shivraj Patil, whom he called his "learned predecessor". Any debate on the Indo-Pak talks was firmly quashed, with Chidambaram saying, "There is no you or I here. The Government has decided." When asked to grade himself, he chose the politically smart option, saying he was "pretty close to zero". He sure knows how to juggle his own balance sheet.

by Priya Sahgal